



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Aquinas Classical Academy

School Website: <https://www.aquinasclassicalacademy.com/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Aquinas Classical Academy (ACA) in Bremerton, WA presents a robust Classical Christian program with a clear Catholic identity. Public materials from ACA emphasize a faith-forward, virtue-oriented formation grounded in Catholic theology, the Magisterium, and the Great Books via a liberal arts curriculum. The pedagogy centers on a blend of contemplative elements and Socratic/seminar-style inquiry, supported by a faculty described as living exemplars and mentors, and a governance and parental-partnership structure that frames parents as primary educators and co-lead-ers in formation. Across six categories, ACA demonstrates a cohesive Classical orientation, aligning strongly with the Six Essential Elements framework.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

Key strengths - Religious and metaphysical foundations are explicit and central (Catholic identity, Magisterium, Our Lady Seat of Wisdom, Aquinas) and integrated into coursework and formation (e.g., faith, reason, virtue; pursuit of truth; education ordered toward eternal good). - Curriculum foregrounds liberal arts (grammar, dialectic, rhetoric), Great Books/primary sources, and Sacred Scripture, with explicit references to history, Western civilization, Latin, and the classical mission. - Pedagogy includes both contemplative/restful elements and Socratic seminars, with emphasis on narration/recitation and public rhetoric in upper grades; learning is framed as a dialogue with primary sources and classical authors. - Faculty are portrayed as forming a living curriculum, with a headmaster and dean of faculty signaling organized mentorship and professional formation; teachers are engaged with classical formation and virtue as central aims. - Parents and community are positioned as partners in formation, with explicit references to parental primacy and collaboration through governance, admissions, and financial-aid pathways; family involvement is a designed feature (shadow days, admissions interviews).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Notes on the keyword framework - Positive keywords anchored in the Six Elements document (e.g., truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; virtue; Great Books; liberal arts; scholé; Socratic method) are clearly reflected in ACA materials (e.g., explicit Catholic identity, Great Books/primary sources, grammar–dialectic–rhetoric curriculum, Socratic/recitation-based pedagogy, and parent partnership). - The Six Essential Elements lexicon (Positive/Negative keywords) provides the framework used to assess each category; ACA

materials align with the positive indicators across categories with few if any signals of negative/anti-classical practices in public materials.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Details

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - ACA describes itself as “obedient to the Magisterium of the Catholic Church” and notes patronage of Our Lady Seat of Wisdom and St. Thomas Aquinas, forming students in faith, reason, and virtue. - The mission emphasizes a liberal arts curriculum “to form students in faith, reason, and virtue” and to seek truth, culminating in eternal happiness with God. - The Philosophy of Education materials reference fides, ratio, virtus (faith, reason, virtue) and the integration of faith with learning. - Additional pages reinforce Catholic culture and intellectual formation through Theology and Sacred Scripture as guiding authorities.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Catholic, Magisterium, Our Lady Seat of Wisdom, St. Thomas Aquinas, faith, reason, virtue, truth, God, divinely oriented formation, sacred scripture, liturgical/catechetical framing (sourced from mission/Philosophy of Education sections and FAQs). - Negative keywords present: None identifiable in public materials; no secularist or relativist signals observed in the accessible content.

Why this rating - The school’s public materials place theology, sacred tradition, and liturgical/habitus elements at the center of education, aligning with the “Grounded in Theology” and “Liturgical/Communal Practices” signals in the Six Elements framework. The explicit Catholic identity and integration of faith with academic formation squarely support a CLASSICAL classification in this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission and program statement frame education as formation: “to form students in faith, reason, and virtue” and “ordered toward teaching students how to learn and seek truth.” - Graduation/college-readiness framing appears in admissions and program notes as preparing students to enter the best colleges, but the primary emphasis remains formation through classical education rather than a purely job-focused outcome. - The curricular and philosophical language emphasizes truth, goodness, beauty as real and knowable, and the cultivation of human excellence through liberal education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, truth, goodness, beauty, classical mission, scholé, contemplation/faith-based formation. - Negative keywords present: The content does not emphasize workforce- or career-prep as primary telos; focus remains on formation and virtue. Public materials show limited to no signals of negative indicators here.

Why this rating - ACA repeatedly frames education as formation of the whole person (virtue, wisdom, and a real telos toward truth and beauty) rather than mere information delivery or job training. The language aligns with the classical telos and paideia ideals, supporting a CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is explicitly described as liberal arts oriented around grammar, dialectic, and rhetoric, with a focus on primary sources and the Great Books. - Public materials reference reading primary sources, focusing on Plato, Aristotle, Boethius, Augustine, Aquinas, and the Church Fathers, and the Great Books of Western Civilization. - Courses described in theology, liturgical context, morality, sacraments, and apologetics indicate integration of classical disciplines with faith-based study. - Additional materials describe Latin, logic, rhetoric, and exposure to Homer, Dante, Shakespeare as part of formation of imagination and intellect.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, grammar, dialectic, rhetoric, Great Books, primary sources, Latin, Homer, Plato, Augustine, Shakespeare, Western civilization, history of salvation, sacred scripture, catechesis, liturgical integration, memory work, recitation, chant, and rhetoric

training. - Negative keywords present: The public materials do not emphasize history as “social studies,” nor do they foreground project-based or STEM-first framing; rather, history is framed in the traditional sense (salvation history, Western civ). This aligns with classical pedagogy rather than its negation.

Why this rating - ACA’s curriculum centers on the liberal arts with the Great Books/primary sources approach, sacred theology integration, and classical languages, meeting the core curriculum criteria of a classical education as defined by the Six Elements lexicon.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe a pedagogy that blends contemplative and rigorous elements, with lower-school singing/chanting/memory practices to deepen memory and delight, and upper-school Socratic discussion and rhetoric training, including opportunities to give speeches. - There is explicit mention of Socratic round-table discussions and the use of primary sources to drive inquiry; the materials articulate a balance of lecture-style and Socratic methods for different grade levels. - Recitation, memory work, and liturgical/catechetical elements are highlighted as integral to the pedagogy. - The philosophy emphasizes wonder and restfulness (Scholé) alongside rigorous classical inquiry.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: scholé, contemplation, wonder, memory work, recitation, chanting, singing to memorize, Socratic/seminar, dialectic, rhetoric, recitation, narration, debate, upper-school rhetoric, public speaking. - Negative keywords present: The public materials do not show a dominant experiential-only or project-based pedagogy; rather, the pedagogy blends classical memory work with Socratic inquiry and recitation, which is consistent with classical pedagogy. No explicit negative signals observed.

Why this rating - ACA’s teaching methods align with classical pedagogy norms: a blend of contemplative/restful learning (scholé), memory/narration/recitation in early levels, and Socratic/seminar-based discourse with upper-level rhetoric and public speaking. This matches the Positive signals for this category in the Six Elements framework.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty are described as model teachers and mentors who form a living curriculum and embody virtue; the faculty are presented as the core of the school, with public bios and leadership (Headmaster, Dean of Faculty) indicating a serious investment in teacher formation. - The school emphasizes a culture of collegiality among teachers and a faculty-led educational vision, with emphasis on primary-source reading and shared scholarly work. - The faculty is framed as lifelong learners with involvement in classical seminars and a standard of virtue associated with the curriculum.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, faculty of friends, collegial culture, lifelong learners, great books seminars for faculty, moral exemplars, virtue, formation, teacher as guide. - Negative keywords present: None observed in public materials (no signals of technocratic, credential-only approaches; no “facilitator on the side” framing appears in the public content).

Why this rating - ACA presents its faculty as a central, virtue-guiding, scholarly community aligned with classical pedagogy. The living-curriculum concept and explicit reference to mentorship and moral exemplars support a CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - ACA positions parents as primary educators with rights and responsibilities in choosing a school aligned with their convictions; the public materials quote CCC 2229 and emphasize parental primacy in education. - The admissions process includes a family interview, and financial-aid structures are designed to support families, signaling ongoing parental involvement and investment in formation. - Public materials highlight programs and events (Shadow Day, open campuses, and family involvement in school life) and supplier of scholarships that engage families in long-term formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parental primacy, parent formation, reading groups/seminars/book clubs (as described in the lexicon and program materials), open campus, family participation. - Negative keywords present: None observed in public materials; no indications of treating parents merely as customers or limiting parental involvement. The materials emphasize ongoing parental engagement.

Why this rating - ACA's materials present a clear framework in which parents are essential collaborators in formation and decision-making, with explicit opportunities for parental involvement and education. This aligns with the CLASSICAL model for the Parents & Community category.

What Would Move the Needle

Not applicable here, as all six categories are CLASSICAL based on the available public materials. No category requires a shift toward a more classical orientation, and no needle-moving changes are necessary to reach CLASSICAL status across all six categories.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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